

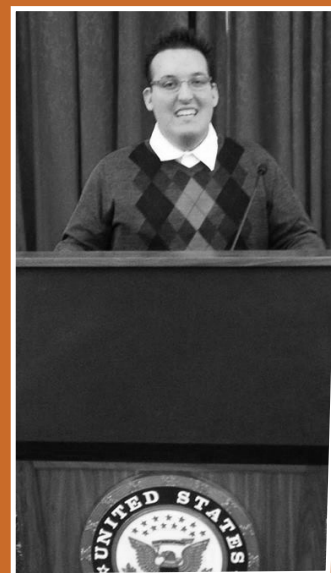
THINK COLLEGE NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER

Annual Report on the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities

Year 4 (2013–2014)

Executive Summary

Meg Grigal, PhD
Debra Hart, MS
Frank A. Smith, MA
Daria Domin, MSW
Jennifer Sulewski, PhD
Cate Weir, MEd



Institute for Community Inclusion
University of Massachusetts Boston



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INTRODUCTION

The Higher Education Act as amended in the Higher Education Opportunity Act contained several provisions aimed at increasing access to higher education for youth and adults with intellectual disabilities (ID). One outcome of these provisions was the appropriation of \$10.6 million by Congress to create a model demonstration program aimed at developing inclusive higher education options for people with ID.

In 2010, the Transition Postsecondary Education Program for Students with Intellectual Disability, or TPSID, model demonstration program was implemented by the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE), which awarded five-year grants to 27 institutes of higher education (IHEs). These IHEs were tasked with creating, expanding, or enhancing high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with ID.

Congress also appropriated \$330,000 for the establishment of a national coordinating center for the TPSID program. OPE awarded the TPSID National Coordinating Center (NCC) to the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston in October 2010. The mission of the NCC is to provide technical assistance to IHEs that offer comprehensive transition and postsecondary programs for students with ID. The NCC also evaluates the TPSID projects, creates recommended standards for programs, and builds a valid and reliable knowledge base around program components.

This Year Four report describes the types of colleges that received TPSID grants, characteristics of attending students, and detailed information about academic access, employment and career development, campus membership, and program elements that supported self-determination, such as person-centered planning. The report also details the TPSID programs' efforts at collaborating with internal and external partners, the extent to which the TPSID programs are integrated into the existing policies and practices of the college, efforts aimed at sustaining these programs, and evaluation strategies employed by the TPSID programs beyond those used by the NCC.

PRIMARY FINDINGS OF THE YEAR FOUR REPORT

This report presents a summary of the most comprehensive data on higher education activities and outcomes for youth with intellectual disabilities currently available. It reflects the potential viability and value of supporting students with intellectual disability to engage in learning and working in higher education environments.

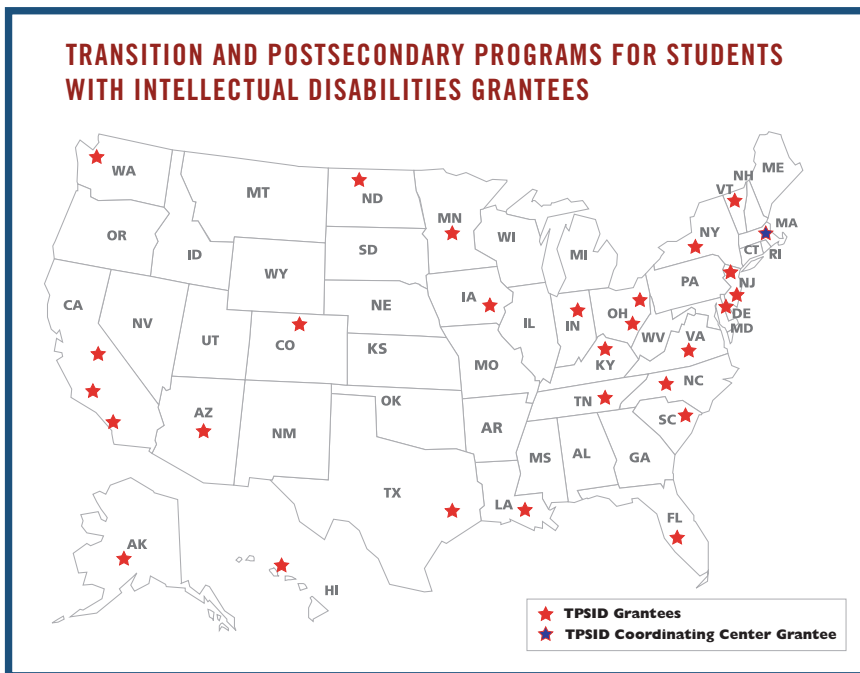
DEMOGRAPHICS

The fourth year of the Transition Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID program) commenced on October 1, 2013, and projects were implemented on 50 college or university campuses in 23 states. In 2013–2014, 15 programs operated on single college campuses, and 12 operated as consortia, with various satellite college campuses. Fifteen of these sites were located at two-year institutes of higher education (IHEs), and 35 sites were located at four-year IHEs.

During Year Four, 883 students attended the 50 TPSID programs, for an average of 18 students per site. As of September 2014, 12 TPSID sites had been approved as a Comprehensive Transition Program and were able to offer eligible students access to certain forms of Title IV student aid. In the 2013–2014 school year, 883 students attended TPSID programs; of these, 438 students were newly enrolled and 445 were continuing students.

In 2013–2014, 58% of students were male and 42% female.¹ The majority of students were white (73%), 15% were black or African American, and 10% were Hispanic or Latino. Over 90% of students were between the ages of 18 and 25, and 92% of enrolled students had an intellectual disability (ID) and/or autism. Just under a quarter of students (24%) were dually enrolled, i.e., receiving special education transition services from a public school system while attending the TPSID program.

¹ Omits data reported at the aggregate level



883
STUDENTS



MEDIAN AGE=20

58%
MALE

42%
FEMALE

24%

PERCENTAGE OF STUDENTS WHO WERE STILL RECEIVING TRANSITION SERVICES THROUGH THEIR LOCAL K-12 SCHOOL DISTRICT.

ACADEMIC ACCESS

In Year Four, course enrollment information was reported for 746 of the 806 students who attended TPSID programs and for whom we had individual (as opposed to aggregate) data. These 746 students enrolled in a total of 5,302 college or university courses. This is an average of seven courses per student taking courses per year.² Students at two-year IHEs took an average of between five and seven courses, while those at four-year IHEs took an average of eight courses a year. A majority of course enrollments (52%) were in academically specialized courses, i.e., courses designed for and delivered to only students with ID in the TPSID. The remaining 48% were in academically inclusive courses, i.e., typical college courses attended by students with ID and other college students. The percentage of enrollments in inclusive courses was higher at two-year IHEs than at four-year IHEs.

The most common accommodations were academic supports, such as note-takers and readers. Students also received enrollment accommodations, such as modified course loads, substitutes for required courses, and priority registration, as well as academic accommodations, such as access to professors' notes, advance access to materials, and alternative test formats. A majority of students attending TPSIDs (79%) were seeking a credential in 2013–2014. A majority (86%) of TPSID programs use peer mentors to provide academic supports to students in the programs.

CAREER DEVELOPMENT AND EMPLOYMENT

Of the 883 students attending TPSID programs in 2013–2014, 347 (39%) held a total of 437 paid jobs. Ninety students with paid jobs had two or more paid jobs in Year Four.³ Seven of these jobs (2%) were those that the student also worked in during Year One, 36 (8%) were jobs the student worked in during Year Two, and 123 (28%) were jobs that students

The findings of this Year Four Annual Report reflect some notable gains. One positive trend is the continued growth in employment status of youth and young adults with intellectual disability (ID) enrolled in these colleges and universities.

Rohan Dawkins

Rohan Dawkins was born in Jamaica, and immigrated with his mother and sister to Delray Beach, Florida during his teenage years. Upon graduation from high school,



he was accepted to the ACCESS program at Lynn University. His goals were to obtain his work permit, obtain employment to help support his family, get a driver's license and become a DJ. During his 2 years there, he audited several college classes, including Radio Production. He also had a radio show at the university and was actively involved in the Lynn Black Student Union. Rohan graduated from Lynn University in May 2014. He has purchased equipment to use in his DJ business. In addition to his business, he works full time at Home Depot. He is currently working in the lot, but will soon be working in the receiving department. Rohan still has dreams that he is working on. He would like to increase his DJ business, purchase a new car and eventually work as a fork lift operator at Home Depot. When asked for a quote to describe his success in life, Rohan says "I take my days one day at a time."

² Some students did not take any courses because they were in a stage of their program where the focus was not on academics, but rather on employment and career development. Therefore, course enrollment data were not reported for some students.

³ Omits data reported at the aggregate level

worked in during Year Three. Forty-eight percent of students employed in Year Four had never held a paid job prior to entering the TPSID.

Individual paid jobs accounted for 271 of the paid jobs held by students (62%), and paid internships (credit and non-credit) accounted for 31%. Ninety-three percent of jobs paid at or above minimum wage. In Year Four, 77% of students participated in career development activities, including paid employment, internships, or other paid or unpaid career development activities. Length of student attendance impacted rates of employment: the longer students attended, the more likely they were to be employed. Challenges to engaging in paid employment included lack of preparation and career assessment prior to students entering their college program, as well as a lack of staff knowledge and training about state-of-the-art customized and integrated employment practices.

SELF-DETERMINATION

In Year Four of the program, person-centered planning was used in 98% of TPSIDs. Students sought academic advising from existing academic advising offices in 54% of TPSIDs, and 46% (n=23) used only a separate advising system specially designed for students who attend the TPSID.

Common motivations for students to enroll in coursework were that the course was required for the TPSID credential (62% of course enrollments), was related to the student's career goals (35%), was related to a personal interest (32%), or was required for a degree or certificate (33%). Year Four saw a decrease in students taking courses because they were related to their career goals (35% of enrollments) when compared to Year Three (52%). Virtually all TPSIDs offered students' families information about IHE-related issues such as social activities (84%), IHE code of conduct (78%), disability-related services available at the IHE (72%), the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) (64%), non-disability-related services (64%), and financial aid (64%).

CAMPUS MEMBERSHIP

In 2013–2014, every TPSID reported facilitating or supporting student participation in campus social activities, including attending events on campus, going out with friends, and attending or participating in sporting events. Some students participated independently; others received support from TPSID staff or peer mentors. A small minority (3.8%) of students was reported as not participating in any social activities.

In 2013–2014, half of TPSIDs (50%) were commuter schools that did not provide housing for any students. Of those TPSIDs located at IHEs that did offer housing, 16 provided students in the TPSID access to that housing, and nine did not. Most of the 174 students living in TPSID- or IHE-provided housing lived in residence halls or off-campus apartments where most residents were other students attending the college. Nearly two thirds of those living off-campus (but not with their families) lived independently, with another 20% in supervised living settings. Students who lived in TPSID or IHE housing generally had higher levels of participation in social activities.

Students who lived in IHE-provided housing had higher levels of participation in social activities overall, and almost all (99%) reported that they engaged socially by going out with personal friends as opposed to attending campus events.

TRAVIS MESSEMER

When Travis Messimer entered the University of Iowa, he came with specific goals – including learning how to be more independent and self-sufficient. Travis has always believed that self-reliance is achieved only through hard work and a willingness to try new things. Ever determined and focused, Travis achieved all of his goals with remarkable success. He now enjoys many friends on campus that he met in his classes, at university events and in student organizations. He communicates regularly with staff, family, and peers about his commitment to self-improvement. He serves as a role model for other students. He has come to enjoy being with others so much that he has periodically planned and hosted his own events in the residence hall communities. Travis's self-determination, his persistence, and his overall dedication to self-improvement makes him a model for all future students. He looks forward to graduating from UI REACH and enjoying life as an independent adult.



EXITING STUDENTS

A total of 316 students exited their TPSID program in Year Four. Overall, 41% of students who exited had a paid job when they exited their program. The most common reason for exit was having completed the program and earned a credential (59%).

Overall, 77% of the students who exited earned one or more credentials before exiting. This is the highest percentage of exiters who earned a credential observed across all four years of data collection. Students who exited programs at four-year IHEs were slightly more likely to have earned a credential than students who exited programs at two-year IHEs (82% versus 71%). A certificate specifically for students in the TPSID program granted by the IHE was the most common credential at both two-year and four-year IHEs.

Three quarters of students who exited in Year Four (75%) were reported as having a paid job, participating in unpaid career development activities, or doing both at the time they exited. At exit, 118 students were working in a paid job and 150 participated in some sort of unpaid career development activities. Forty-three students were both employed for pay and participating in unpaid career development activities when they exited their program. Students who were dually enrolled in high school and college in their final year were less likely to exit their program with a paid job than students who were enrolled as an adult student.

EVALUATION

Each TPSID, in addition to using the NCC evaluation system, created its own mechanisms for self-assessment. The evaluation tools used by TPSIDs included assessment of students' academic and career interests and progress, goal attainment, and self-determination. TPSIDs regularly sought feedback from students, faculty, peer mentors, family members, TPSID staff, and employers of students via interviews and meetings. Fifty-four percent of TPSIDs also collected follow-up data on students who exited the program, reflecting a steady increase over time starting with 23% in Year One.

54% of TPSID programs reported collecting follow-up data on their students, up from only 23% in Year 1.

ALIGNMENT WITH COLLEGE SYSTEMS AND PRACTICES

In Year Four, TPSID programs followed the academic calendar used by the IHE at 92% of the reporting TPSIDs (N=50). Almost all (98%) indicated that they held students to the IHE's code of conduct, and 91% issued students college or university ID cards. Eighty-two percent issued students a transcript. Almost two thirds of programs issued regular transcripts. Forty percent of TPSIDs stated that students accessed all campus resources that were listed as options in the evaluation system. The most commonly accessed resources were the student center, dining hall, computer lab or IT services, bookstore, and library. Growth in the percentage of campuses at which students use career and tutoring services grew consistently from Years One through Three and stabilized at around 60% in Year Four.

COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION

The 50 participating TPSIDs partnered with 240 external organizations.

The most common external partnerships in Year Four were with vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies, local education agencies (LEAs), employers, University Centers for Excellence in Developmental Disabilities, and state IDD services agencies. Year Four is the first year that VR agencies were the most frequent partner, with LEAs being the most frequent partner in Years One through Three. The three most common partner roles were participating in a project advisory committee, providing services directly to students, and providing career development services to students. The percentage of TPSIDs partnering with employers increased from 29% in Year One to 46% in Year Four. Staff from 74% of TPSIDs participated in professional development provided by their IHE, and 78% had staff that participated in professional development provided by an entity external to the IHE.

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SUSTAINABILITY

In Year Four, 90% of TPSIDs received financial support from external sources, such as state VR agencies and state IDD services agencies. In 20 of the 37 instances where VR agencies partnered with TPSID programs, the agency provided funds for student tuition. For tuition and non-tuition expenses, private pay (i.e., personal funds) was the option most commonly used. Tuition was waived for various reasons for 10% of students. Twelve TPSID sites were approved comprehensive transition programs (CTPs), and could offer eligible students access to certain forms of federal student aid. Pell Grants were the most common form of federal student aid. Annual costs of the TPSID programs varied widely, ranging from no cost at all to \$51,000, and depended upon the type of institution (two-year or four-year) and whether the IHE charges were residency-dependent, e.g., in-state, out-of-state, city resident, etc.

CONCLUSION

The full Year 4 TPSID report presents the most comprehensive data on higher education activities and outcomes for youth with intellectual disabilities currently available. It reflects the potential viability and value of supporting students with intellectual disability to engage in learning and working in higher education environments. It also highlights that challenges remain in creating inclusive learning opportunities in a higher education context.

The findings of this Year Four Annual Report reflect some notable gains as well as continued challenges faced by institutions of higher education (IHEs) implementing TPSID programs. One positive trend is the continued growth in employment status of youth and young adults with intellectual disability (ID) enrolled in these colleges and universities. While national rates of employment for youth with similar disabilities have stagnated during recent years (Butterworth, Migliore, Sulewski, & Zalewska, 2014), the employment rate for students in the TPSID programs has increased incrementally each program year, beginning in Year One at 30% and steadily climbing to 39% in Year Four.

An area that continues to challenge the IHEs implementing TPSID programs is access to inclusive (rather than specialized) coursework. While some colleges and universities have developed and expanded inclusive course access, the majority of course enrollments continue to be in specialized courses, designed for and attended only by students with disabilities. The continuing use of primarily specialized coursework has significant implications. As the TPSIDs represent the first large-scale investment in development and demonstration of model programs, other IHEs throughout the country look to these programs as leaders in the field. Replication of current program models could lead to an increase in segregated models of instruction in higher education.

The TPSID program has created a foundation of knowledge that can inform the emerging field of inclusive higher education. To ensure that we reap the best outcomes from these efforts, high expectations and positive intentions must be manifested in the creation of access to inclusive learning, living, and working opportunities.

ACCESS THE FULL YEAR 4 ANNUAL REPORT:

www.thinkcollege.net/publications/tpsid-annual-reports

RECOMMENDED CITATION

Grigal, M., Hart, D., Smith, F. A., Domin, D., Sulewski, J., Weir, C. (2015). *Think College National Coordinating Center: Annual report on the transition and postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disabilities (2013–2014)—Executive Summary*. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.